Lesson 41 material: Pathos and Ethos

5.4: Identifying and Using Pathos

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

(Picture: black and white heart-shaped print with a fingerprint pattern)

Figure: "Fingerprint Heart Swirls Love UniqueId Pattern" by Max Pixel is licensed under CC-0 1.0

What is pathos?

The definition of empathy is "to see with the other person's eyes, to hear with another's ears, to feel with the heart of the Other." Albert Adler, 1930

Persuasive writing is more than an intellectual puzzle or a fight. Our goal as writers is also to build empathy—that through our words, our readers will "see our point of view" by feeling connected in their minds and hearts. We use appeals to pathos—emotion, senses, and story—to make these connections.

As readers, we analyze appeals to pathos by looking for these roads to our hearts and figuring out if the writer is using them effectively and sincerely.

Some of us imagine that we are rational and make decisions mostly based on logic. However, our emotions and values may guide us more than we think. In fact, studies that reveal our brains' electrical activity show that reading stories can let us "mirror" the experiences of characters, and reading sensory imagery can make us "feel" the ideas.

Neuroscientists have done many studies in which subjects read different texts while inside a functional magnetic resonance imaging (fMRI) brain scanning machine that records electrical activity in different brain regions. According to Annie Murphy Paul's *New York Times* piece "Your Brain on Fiction," neuroscientists have known for a long time that when we read any words, two main small areas of the brain light up with activity: Wernicke's and Broca's areas, the parts that interpret and produce language.

Figure 5.4.2 highlights the two brain regions that show activity when reading facts:

(Picture: a gray diagram of the brain, showing activation in just 2 parts which are related to speech)

Figure: "Motor and Sensory Regions of the Cerebral Cortex" by Bruce Blaus is licensed under CC-BY 3.0

But what happens when instead of reading facts, we read stories that describe other peoples' experiences and feelings? It turns out that the reader's brain activity looks very different.

What does pathos do to a reader's brain?

In a 2014 study, neuroscientists at Carnegie Mellon University had subjects read a section from *Harry Potter* while in an fMRI. When a character walked, the subject's motor cortex lit up like they were walking, and when the characters talked to each other, more regions of the brain lit up besides the usual language parts - the parts we use in real life to think about other people's motivations and recognize different faces. Several other studies cited by Paul used similar methods to show that when we read metaphors that use sensory images, our brains process them as if we were touching real textures or smelling real smells. She cites a team of researchers from Emory University who found that "metaphors like 'The singer had a velvet voice' and 'He had leathery hands' roused the sensory cortex, while phrases matched for meaning, like 'The singer had a pleasing voice' and 'He had strong hands,' did not."

Figure 5.4.3 shows the brain regions that show activity when reading stories and metaphors:

(Picture: diagram of the brain showing 11 distinct areas activated, including the visual, motor, and auditory cortex)

Figure: "Motor and Sensory Regions of the Cerebral Cortex" by Bruce Blaus is licensed under CC-BY 3.0

Besides our ability to "see" images described in words we read, we can "feel" other peoples' emotions, too, as they are reflected by "mirror neurons" in our brains. According to a Dutch Science Foundation article, "Neuroimaging experiments show that we activate common circuits when observing sensations or emotions felt by others, and when experiencing these sensations and emotions ourselves," our brains mirror other people's pain, fear, and disgust as if we were feeling them ourselves.

How do writers use pathos?

Persuasive writers, politicians, and advertisers all use this power of pathos to get us, their audience, to support their ideas and buy their products. You may have had a writing teacher ask you to "show, not tell" - to give details so that the reader can "see" the situation in their "mind's eye." This works in an argumentative essay as well as in a poem or novel. Advertisements, speeches, and editorials use pathos to make us feel angry, afraid, hungry, protective, and passionate.

Even in very formal writing, such as academic books or journals, an author often will try to present an issue in such a way as to connect to the feelings or attitudes of their audience. When you evaluate pathos, you are asking whether a speech or essay arouses the audience's interest and sympathy. You are looking for the elements of the essay or speech that might cause the audience to feel an emotional or sensory connection to the content.

When writing the article in the exercise below, the author used a terrible workplace accident in Bangladesh (see figure 5.4.4) as an example to illustrate working conditions in textile factories.

(Picture: a person in front of a crowd with a pained expression holds up a small photo of a woman)

Figure: A relative of one of the workers in a clothing factory at Rana Plaza, Bangladesh, holds up the picture of his missing family member, presumed dead. "Bangladesh-building" by Weronika is licensed under CC-BY 2.0.

Finding pathos

Let's look at this text to find examples of pathos in use:

Try this!

Read this passage from Jimenez and Pulos' textbook on corporations and sweatshops. Look for obvious and not-so-obvious examples of pathos.

Reading from a textbook: "Corporate Social Responsibility and Sweatshops."

On April 24, 2013, at Rana Plaza on the outskirts of Dhaka, Bangladesh, a building containing apparel factories collapsed, trapping and killing over 1,100 employees. It was not only the worst industrial disaster in the history of the garment industry, it was also the world's most fatal industrial building collapse. News reports soon emerged that the factory owners had ignored ominous warning signs, such as visible cracks in the wall, and had illegally added several stories to the top of the building, creating a weight the building could not bear. Many of the factories operating in the building were producing apparel for well-known Western brands, such as Walmart, Joe Fresh, and Mango.

Rescue workers struggled for over a week to reach trapped survivors, while hospitals tended to the over 2,500 workers who had escaped, many with severe injuries. Survivors told heart-rending tales of having lost mothers and sisters who had worked in the same factories. The deaths of so many innocent workers created a firestorm of controversy in Bangladesh and around the world. Accusations and recriminations were leveled at corporations and government officials. A period of intense and profound soul-searching ensued for the global fashion companies that made substantial use of outsourced factory labor in Bangladesh. Within a few months, two major initiatives were announced, one American and one European, to increase safety and accountability in Bangladeshi factories.

Adding pathos

Now let's apply this to your writing:

Apply this!

Take a piece of writing you are working on and read it over. It's not always appropriate to use pathos, depending on the subject and assignment (probably not in a science lab report), but if it is appropriate, look for places you can connect to your readers' senses, values, and emotions by adding

- vivid, specific description and imagery
- metaphors or similes to help your reader "see" what you are describing
- short narrative examples

Work Cited

Jimenez, Guillermo C., and Elizabeth Pulos. *Good Corporation, Bad Corporation: Corporate Social Responsibility in the Global Economy*. Open SUNY Textbooks, 2014. Licensed under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.

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Links on the original page

- " Fingerprint Heart Swirls Love: https://www.maxpixel.net/Fingerprint-Heart-Swirls-Love-Unique-Id-Pattern-2750394
- Good Corporation, Bad Corporation: Corporate Social Responsibility in the Global Economy : https://milnepublishing.geneseo.edu/good-corporation-bad-corporation/
- Good Corporation, Bad Corporation: Corporate Social Responsibility in the Global Economy : https://milnepublishing.geneseo.edu/good-corporation-bad-corporation/chapter/9-csr-and-sweatshops/

5.5: Identifying and Using Ethos

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

(Picture: black and white icon of a human figure with a badge and a checkmark)

Figure: **Ethos** "Integrity" by Adrien Coquet from NounProject.com is licensed under CC-BY

What is ethos?

How do we know what is true or what we should decide? Often, we rely on the promises of other people. If a friend tells us about a surprising new cure for a disease, we might ask, "Where did you hear that?" If we are choosing a restaurant in a new city, or a college class, or a pair of shoes, we look at online reviews to get the advice of other people in our same situations.

An appeal to ethos is all about trust. The word means "character" and is related to ethics, the study of social morals, or how we all decide together what is right and wrong, and who we can trust to tell the truth. One source may have credibility because of their educational, professional, or official status, or like the protestor in figure 5.5.1, have credibility because they have personal experience with the situation.

(Picture: young women in a crowd hold up handmade signs, one reading "I don't want to die for fashion")

Figure: "Thousands of garment workers and their unions rally on the one-year anniversary of the Rana Plaza collapse that killed more than 1,100 garment workers" by Solidarity Center is licensed under CC-BY-ND 2.0

How do we look for ethos as readers?

As a reader, evaluating *ethos* means asking who's talking (or writing) and how much we can trust them.

- Are they fair?
- Are they experts on the subject?
- Are they using other trustworthy sources?

How do we use ethos as writers?

When you are the writer, you imagine that your audience is asking the same questions, and you want them to trust you. In order to do this well, you need to establish *ethos* by doing the following:

- present your argument clearly, in a way that makes you sound authoritative and professional (see 2.3: Writing a Thesis Statement)
- not exaggerate the strength of your claims and perhaps use hedging language to make your position sound thoughtful and reasonable (See 5.9: Hedging)
- explain and respond to opposite or alternative positions on the topic fairly so your reader sees that you have considered the full picture (see 5.8: Concession and Counterargument)
- Use evidence from other trusted sources and clearly show why we should trust them by citing them accurately and providing their credentials. (see 4.7 Introducing and Explaining Evidence)

Examples of ethos

Notice this!

In this excerpt from the article Waste Couture: Environmental Impact of the Clothing Industry by Luz Claudio, notice the places where the author establishes ethos for herself and for her other sources. **Bold** shows the parts to notice; [purple type in brackets shows the explanation].

Printable Word version: How writers build ethos.docx

Printable PDF version: How writers build ethos.pdf

Reading from an academic journal article: Everything Old Is New Again

In her book *Waste and Want: A Social History of Trash*, Susan Strasser, a professor of history at the University of Delaware, [Here Claudio is telling us the credential for the author she is citing] traces the "progressive obsolescence" of clothing and other consumer goods to the 1920s. Before then, and especially during World War I, most clothing was repaired, mended, or tailored to fit other family members, or recycled within the home as rags or quilts. During the war, clothing manufacturers reduced the varieties, sizes, and colors of their productions and even urged designers to create styles that would use less fabric and avoid needless decoration. The government's conservation campaign used slogans such as "Make economy fashionable lest it become obligatory" and resulted in an approximate 10% reduction in the production of trash.

However, the spirit of conservation did not last long; by the mid-1920s consumerism was back in style. Industrialization grew in the twentieth century, providing the means of increased production of all consumer goods. During World War II, consumption rose with increased employment as the United States mobilized for the war. The production and consumption of many household goods, including clothing, grew by 10–15% even in the middle of the war and continues to expand to this day.

Industrialization brought consumerism with it as an integral part of the economy. **Economic growth came to depend on continued marketing of new products and disposal of old ones that are thrown away simply because stylistic norms promote their obsolescence.** [Here Claudio is zooming out to explain a larger cause behind what seem like foolish individual decisions by consumers. This builds ethos by showing the author's

reasonable acknowledgment of the bigger picture.] When it comes to clothing, the rate of purchase and disposal has dramatically increased, so the path that a T-shirt travels from the sales floor to the landfill has become shorter.

Yet even today, the journey of a piece of clothing does not always end at the landfill. [Here Claudio is conceding that some progress is being made toward reducing negative environmental impacts.] A portion of clothing purchases are recycled mainly in three ways: clothing may be resold by the primary consumer to other consumers at a lower price, it may be exported in bulk for sale in developing countries, or it may be chemically or mechanically recycled into raw material for the manufacture of other apparel and non-apparel products.

Domestic resale has boomed in the era of the Internet. Many people sell directly to other individuals through auction websites such as eBay. Another increasingly popular outlet is consignment and thrift shops, where sales are growing at a pace of 5% per year, **according to the National Association of Resale and Thrift Shops** [providing the source of the statistic]**.**

The U.S. government offers tax incentives for citizens who donate household goods to charities such as the Salvation Army and Goodwill Industries, which salvage a portion of clothing and textiles that would otherwise go to landfills or incinerators. The trend of increased purchasing of clothing and other household goods has served the salvage charities well. For instance, since 2001 Goodwill Industries has seen a 67% increase in its sale of donated goods, most of it clothing. **Figures from the National Association of Resale and Thrift Shops** [providing the source of the statistic] put Goodwill's sales of donated goods at thrift shops at more than $1.8 billion in 2006.

Finding ethos

Now let's look at another article and practice finding examples of *ethos* in action:

Try this!

In this section of a chapter from Good Corporation, Bad Corporation: Corporate Social Responsibility in the Global Economy (Jimenez and Pulos), the authors have already discussed the terrible working conditions and labor abuses in factories known as "sweatshops." Now they are presenting a different perspective. Look for the ways they establish *ethos* for themselves and the sources they cite.

Reading from a business ethics textbook: The Other Side of the Story: In Praise of Sweatshops

In light of the above history, it might seem startling that many experts appear to accept the existence of sweatshops as something positive. Economist Jeffrey Sachs, who is perhaps the world's foremost expert on the eradication of poverty (he was the creator of the United Nations Millennium Project to cut global poverty in half) was quoted in 1997 as saying, "The problem with sweatshops is not that there are too many, but that there are not enough." What did he mean by that?

In general, economists are less disturbed by sweatshop abuses than are labor activists, but most economists would deny that this is because they are heartless or unconcerned with human rights. Rather, they concede that sweatshop abuses are both common and reprehensible, but they also believe that the benefits to the local economy from international outsourcing more than outweigh the harm.

According to this point of view, sweatshops are part of the industrialization process and are an inevitable by-product of economic development. Factories in poor countries are able to attract foreign customers because local labor is cheap. As factories proliferate and employment rises, factories must begin to compete for better workers. Wages therefore increase, and factory conditions improve. With a broader tax base and greater economic growth, local governments are able to invest in the infrastructure for further development, building roads, hospitals, and schools.

Some international research studies appear to confirm the economists' point of view. One study revealed that, in most countries where the presence of sweatshops had been reported, apparel factory workers actually earned more than the average national wage. A number of countries have passed through a manufacturing phase in which sweatshop conditions were more prevalent on their way to full industrialization and a diversified economy. Examples include the United States, Japan, and Korea. Most recently, China appears to be following a similar path, though it is still in a transition phase and reports of sweatshop abuses are still common.

Adding ethos

Now let's apply this to your own writing:

Apply this:

Look at your own or a classmate's draft. Where can you add or revise parts to establish *ethos*?

- Look at your thesis statement. Can you revise it to make it sound more reasonable and thoughtful?
- Look at your text evidence. Can you add/revise credentials to introduce your sources with information to build their credibility? Do you need to find more credible sources?
- Look at your concessions and counterarguments. Can you add/revise parts to show you are representing opposing points of view fairly and have considered all the most obvious angles to your topic?
- Are there any places you can use hedging language to limit your claims and make them easier to defend?

When writers misuse ethos

Ethos is important, but can't stand alone. Here are two ways writers misuse ethos:

1. Sometimes writers don't use enough logical evidence, and instead, rely on emphasizing ethos—who is saying the idea. They present a quote or paraphrase that looks like it's going to be evidence, but it's actually just the same idea they already said again, but written by a credible source. This is usually unintentional, but weakens an argument.

Example: A writer wants to support this claim: **Producing fabric causes damage to both the environment and society.**

Here are three possible support sentences with evidence from a credible source. Which one misuses ethos?

A. According to a team of researchers from Washington University, these harms range from "the growth of water-intensive cotton, to the release of untreated dyes into local water sources, to worker's low wages and poor working conditions" (Bick, et al.).

B. According to a team of researchers from Washington University, "The environmental and social costs involved in textile manufacturing are widespread" (Bick, et al.).
C. According to a team of researchers from Washington University, this damage is not always easy to see: "The human and environmental health risks associated with inexpensive clothing are hidden throughout the lifecycle of each garment" (Bick, et al.).

All three support sentences use quoted evidence from a credible source, and introduce the quote with a credential. But A and C both add something new and more specific to the first sentence. B does not; it is the same level of specificity as the first sentence. It is depending on the credibility of the source, not building a logical argument.

2. Sometimes writers (especially marketers) intentionally use *ethos* to get their readers to believe or buy something by focusing on who is endorsing their product or idea rather than what's good about the product or idea. Often the person cited is not even an expert on the topic. This is called an Appeal to Authority or Appeal to False Authority, and is included in 5.7: Logical Fallacies.

Works Cited

Bick, Rachel, et al. "The global environmental injustice of fast fashion." *Environmental Health*, vol. 17, no. 92, 27 Dec. 2018, doi:https://doi.org/10.1186/s12940-018-0433-7.

Jimenez, Guillermo C., and Elizabeth Pulos. *Good Corporation, Bad Corporation: Corporate Social Responsibility in the Global Economy*. Open SUNY Textbooks, 2014, milnepublishing.geneseo.edu/good-corporation-bad-corporation/. Licensed under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0

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Claudio, Luz. “Waste Couture: Environmental Impact of the Clothing Industry.” *Environmental Health Perspectives*, vol. 115, no. 9, Sept. 2007, pp. A448–A454. *EBSCOhost*, doi:10.1289/ehp.115-a449. Reproduced from *Environmental Health Perspectives* with permission from the author.

Links on the original page

- "Integrity": https://thenounproject.com/icon/integrity-3201900/
- Waste Couture: Environmental Impact of the Clothing Industry: https://doi.org/10.1289/ehp.115-a449
- Good Corporation, Bad Corporation: Corporate Social Responsibility in the Global Economy: https://milnepublishing.geneseo.edu/good-corporation-bad-corporation
- Web page (doi.org): https://doi.org/10.1186/s12940-018-0433-7
- Good Corporation, Bad Corporation: Corporate Social Responsibility in the Global Economy : https://milnepublishing.geneseo.edu/good-corporation-bad-corporation/chapter/9-csr-and-sweatshops/

Attached: How writers build ethos

How writers build ethos

In this excerpt from the article [Waste Couture: Environmental Impact of the Clothing Industry] by Luz Claudio, notice the places where the author establishes ethos for herself and for her other sources. [Bold] shows the parts to notice.

Reading from an academic journal article: Everything Old Is New Again

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| Claudio, Luz. “Waste Couture: Environmental Impact of the Clothing Industry.” Environmental Health Perspectives, vol. 115, no. 9, Sept. 2007, pp. A448–A454. EBSCOhost, doi:10.1289/ehp.115-a449. Reproduced from Environmental Health Perspectives with permission from the author. Annotation by Gabriel Winer, Berkeley City College |

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The author comes back to limit the concession: She started by saying we are discarding a huge and increasing amount of clothing since the 1920s; then concedes that some efforts are being made to reduce the waste and explains those different efforts; then reminds us that all of these efforts only save a little bit of the clothing from being discarded as quickly.The author comes back to limit the concession: She started by saying we are discarding a huge and increasing amount of clothing since the 1920s; then concedes that some efforts are being made to reduce the waste and explains those different efforts; then reminds us that all of these efforts only save a little bit of the clothing from being discarded as quickly.providing the source of the statistic providing the source of the statistic A 2006 survey [conducted by America’s Research Group, a consumer trends research firm], found that about 12–15% of Americans shop at consignment or resale stores. [The Council for Textile Recycling] estimates that 2.5 billion pounds of post-consumer textile waste (which includes anything made of fabric) is thus collected and prevented from entering directly into the waste stream. This represents 10 pounds for every person in the United States, [but it is still only about 15% of the clothing that is discarded].